

City Routes

Zhangjiajie → Fenghuang →

Changsha: Fantasy

Mountains, Ancient Town &

CDISCOVERY  
Spicy Food (5-6 Days)

<https://cdiscovery-community.netlify.app/>

# Zhangjiajie → Fenghuang → Changsha: Fantasy

## Mountains, Ancient Town & Spicy Food (5-6 Days)

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This 5-6 day route through Hunan province (湖南) takes you from the otherworldly pillar mountains of Zhangjiajie through the dreamy riverside town of Fenghuang to the fiery food capital of Changsha. It's a journey through landscapes that inspired Avatar, a 300-year-old Miao minority town frozen in time, and a city where food is life and everything is spicy.

### Day 1-2: Zhangjiajie -- Avatar Mountains

Day 1: Zhangjiajie National Forest Park -- Yuanjiajie (袁家界) & Golden Whip Stream (金鞭溪)

Start early at the Zhangjiajie National Forest Park (张家界国家森林公园) -- 4,810 hectares

of towering sandstone pillars rising through misty clouds. Take the Bailong Elevator

(百龙天梯, the world's tallest outdoor elevator at 326m, ¥72 one way) up to Yuanjiajie --

the "Avatar Hallelujah Mountain" (哈利路亚山, officially "South Sky Pillar" 南天一柱) is

here. Walk the loop trail (2-3 hours) for views of the First Bridge Under Heaven

(天下第一桥) -- a natural stone bridge connecting two pillars, 350m above the valley

floor. In the afternoon, hike Golden Whip Stream (金鞭溪) -- a 7.5 km flat valley trail along

a crystal-clear stream between towering pillars. The morning mist and afternoon

sunlight create completely different moods.

07:00-18:00 | ¥225 (4-day pass) + ¥72 (Bailong Elevator one way) | ! Buy the 4-day pass --

you'll need it

Day 2: Tianzi Mountain (天子山) & Yangjiajie (杨家界)

Take the cable car up Tianzi Mountain (天子山, ¥72 one way) for the most spectacular panoramic views. The "Imperial Writing Brush" peaks (御笔峰) and the "Sea of Clouds" (云海) phenomenon on misty mornings are Zhangjiajie's most iconic images. In the afternoon, hike the Yangjiajie section for the "Natural Great Wall" (天然长城) -- a ridge of rock formations that genuinely resembles the Great Wall of China from a distance. This section has fewer tourists than Yuanjiajie.

07:00-18:00 | Included in 4-day pass | 天子山索道 ¥72 one way

## Day 3-4: Fenghuang Ancient Town -- Miao Minority Heritage

Getting There: Bus from Zhangjiajie to Fenghuang (凤凰古城)

The bus from Zhangjiajie Central Bus Station (张家界中心汽车站) to Fenghuang takes approximately 4 hours (¥80-100). The route winds through stunning mountain scenery --

keep your camera ready. Alternatively, take a train to Jishou (吉首) station (2.5 hours, ¥50) then bus to Fenghuang (1 hour, ¥25). Arrive in the late afternoon for the best experience -- Fenghuang transforms at sunset.

### Day 3 Evening: Tuojiang River Night View (沱江夜景)

Fenghuang Ancient Town (凤凰古城) is a 300-year-old town built along the banks of the Tuojiang River (沱江), home to the Miao (苗族) and Tujia (土家族) ethnic minorities. The town's magic happens at sunset when thousands of red lanterns illuminate the stilted houses (吊脚楼) built on wooden stilts over the river. Walk along the riverside promenade, cross the stone bridges, and watch the reflections of illuminated buildings shimmering on the water. Rent a small boat (乌篷船, ¥30/person) for a river cruise through the illuminated town -- the reflections are mesmerizing. This is the most photographed scene in Fenghuang.

24/7 | 免费（古城自2016年起免费开放） | 乌篷船 ¥30/人

#### Day 4: Exploring Fenghuang -- Miao Culture & Stilted Houses

Spend the day exploring the town's cultural depth. Visit the Former Residence of Shen Congwen (沈从文故居) -- the legendary author whose novel "Border Town" (边城) put Fenghuang on the literary map. Walk through the Miao ethnic minority neighborhoods, where women still wear traditional silver headdresses weighing up to 3 kg. Try Miao specialties: 血粑鸭 (blood cake duck, a savory-sweet delicacy), 社饭 (she fan, herb rice wrapped in leaves), and 酸汤鱼 (sour soup fish). Visit the Hong Bridge (虹桥) -- a covered stone bridge with shops and a tea house offering panoramic river views from the second floor.

08:00-17:30 | 免费（故居免费开放）



## Day 5-6: Changsha -- Hunan's Spicy Capital

Getting There: HSR Fenghuang → Changsha

Take a bus from Fenghuang to Jishou West Station (吉首西站, 1 hour, ¥25), then HSR to Changsha South Station (长沙南站) -- approximately 2.5 hours, ¥165 second class. The train passes through dramatic Hunan mountain scenery and tunnels.

Day 5 Afternoon: Orange Island (橘子洲) & Yuelu Mountain (岳麓山)

Orange Island (橘子洲) is a long, narrow island in the Xiang River (湘江) -- famous for the massive 32-meter-tall young Mao Zedong sculpture (青年毛泽东雕塑) at its southern tip, depicting the revolutionary leader at age 32. Take the free electric shuttle (观光车, ¥20 round trip) along the island's 5 km length. Then cross to the west bank for Yuelu Mountain (岳麓山) -- a scenic hill dotted with ancient temples and the thousand-year-old Yuelu Academy (岳麓书院, one of China's four great ancient academies, founded 976 AD).

The Aiwan Pavilion (爱晚亭) at the mountain's foot is one of China's four famous pavilions -- especially beautiful when surrounded by red maple leaves in autumn.

橘子洲 07:00-22:00 / 岳麓山 07:00-22:00 / 岳麓书院 08:00-17:30 | 橘子洲免费 / 岳麓书院 ¥50

Day 5 Evening: Hunan Cuisine (湘菜) -- Stinky Tofu & Beyond

Changsha is the spiritual home of Chinese street food culture. The signature dish is

臭豆腐 (chòu dòufu, "stinky tofu") -- deep-fried fermented tofu with a crispy exterior and soft, spicy interior. The smell is terrible; the taste is addictive. Try it at the most famous

stall on Taiping Street (太平街). Also must-try: 剁椒鱼头 (duòjiāo yútóu, steamed fish

head with chopped chili peppers, ¥68-98) -- Hunan's most iconic dish. And 口味虾

(kǒuwèi xiā, Changsha-style spicy crayfish, ¥88-128/份) -- the city's obsession every

summer. For the best 剁椒鱼头, try

Yu's Family Kitchen (炊烟时代)



or

Xiao Chuan (小炒黄牛肉)

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11:00-21:30 | ¥60-100/person | Must-try: 剁椒鱼头, 小炒黄牛肉, 口味虾

## Day 6: Taiping Street (太平街) & Departure

Taiping Street is Changsha's most atmospheric historic street -- a 375m Qing Dynasty lane lined with traditional buildings, snack stalls, teahouses, and cultural shops. It's the epicenter of Changsha's street food scene. Try 茶颜悦色 (Chayan Yuese) -- Changsha's cult-status tea brand that doesn't exist outside Hunan (people queue 30+ minutes for their "You Sheng" series). The street also has the Jia Yi Memorial Hall (贾谊故居, free), the former residence of a famous Han Dynasty scholar. For a modern Changsha experience, visit the IFS Tower observation area -- the rooftop has the iconic Kaws sculpture and

panoramic city views.

全天 / 店铺 10:00-22:00 | 茶颜悦色 ¥15-20/杯

## Route Tips

\* Spice Level:

\* Hunan cuisine (湘菜) is among the spiciest in China -- it's "fragrant-spicy" (香辣)

without Sichuan's numbing sensation. Stinky tofu and fish head are less spicy than they

look. Ask for wēi là (微辣) at restaurants if needed.

\* Zhangjiajie → Fenghuang:

\* The 4-hour bus ride is scenic but can be nauseating on mountain roads. Take motion

sickness medicine if prone. The bus station is in central Zhangjiajie city.

\* Weather:

\* Hunan is hot and humid in summer (35 degC+). Zhangjiajie is famous for mist -- it

makes the pillars MORE beautiful. Spring (April-May) and autumn

(September-November) are ideal. Winter can be cold but uncrowded.

\* Budget Estimate:

\* ¥3,500-6,000 per person for 6 days (mid-range). Zhangjiajie park: ¥225 + ¥200 in cable

cars/elevator. Bus to Fenghuang: ¥80-100. Fenghuang to Changsha: ¥190. Hotels:

¥150-400/night.

\* Fenghuang at Night:

\* The town is magical after dark -- arrive by late afternoon and stay at least one night.

The riverside hostels with balcony views of the illuminated town are unforgettable

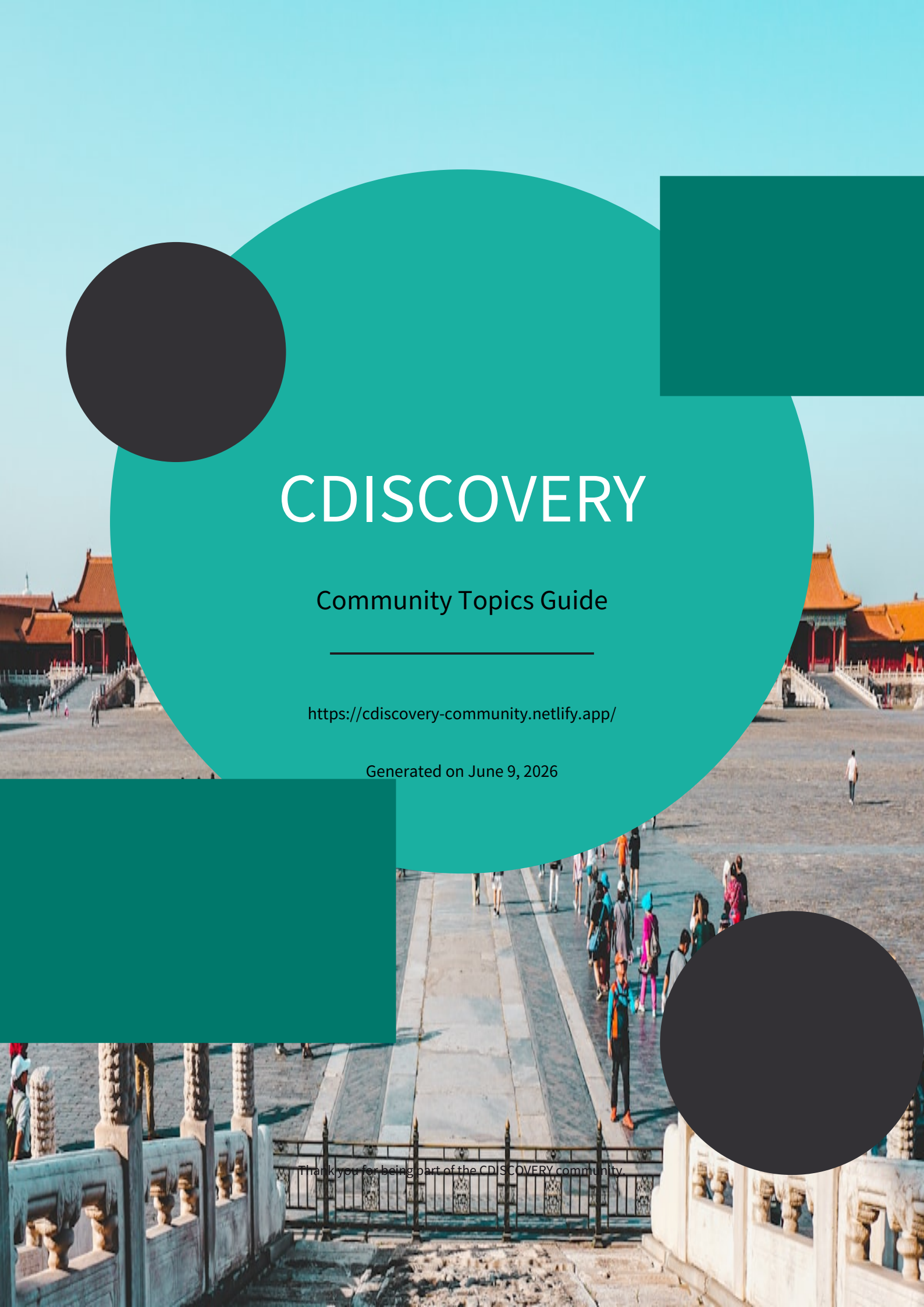
(¥200-500/night). Book ahead in peak season.

\* Essential Apps:

\* 高德地图 (navigation), 12306 (train booking), 美团 (food delivery & deals), WeChat Pay /

Alipay (payments).

Sources: Sources: [Zhangjiajie Tourism](https://www.zjjtravel.net) • [Fenghuang Ancient Town](https://www.fenghuangtravel.com) • [Changsha Government](https://www.changsha.gov.cn) • [Travel China Guide](https://www.travelchinaguide.com)



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## Community Topics Guide

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